

BLK II - UNIT 4: METOC Workplace Operations

a. METOC Workplace Operations

The goal of the PC will be to show you have the capability to follow guidance and use critical thinking skills to simulate a day in the life of an operational METOC Forecaster. To successfully demonstrate competency in this objective, you will be given a series of questions and tasks designed to display your ability to communicate via phone and email correctly, as well as take into consideration the operational impacts and potential disruptions to daily tasks. For the remainder of this objective, follow your instructor's guidance as they provide instruction for completing the requirements for this objective.

Professional Workplace Communication

Phone Etiquette

While on shift, there will be times that you will be required to answer the phone. When answering the phone, you should always try have something to write with and something to write on in case the call is important enough to need to write down information. You should also keep the phone call to business/military conversations only. DO NOT use military phones for personal use. When answering the phone open with a greeting, your location, your name & rank.

Receiving Calls:

1. Ensure the phone is always on, serviceable, and in working order.
2. Always have a pen and paper ready, to write down pertinent information.
3. Try to answer the phone within the first 3 rings.
4. Respond to the caller by first stating your organization, rank and last name.
5. Be polite when answering calls. Do not speak loudly and avoid responding with the following mannerisms:
 - a. Distress
 - b. Sarcasm
 - c. Tiredness
 - d. Exertion
6. Listen carefully to all words of the caller. Pay attention to any clues or specific details in the message, write them down if you need to.
 - a. If you do not understand things in the conversation, do not hesitate to ask them to repeat the information.
7. Summarize what the caller has said using your own words. If you must repeat any information back verbatim, do so in a polite manner.

8. Confirm with the caller everything that they are requesting and ask politely if there's anything else that they would need.

Placing Calls

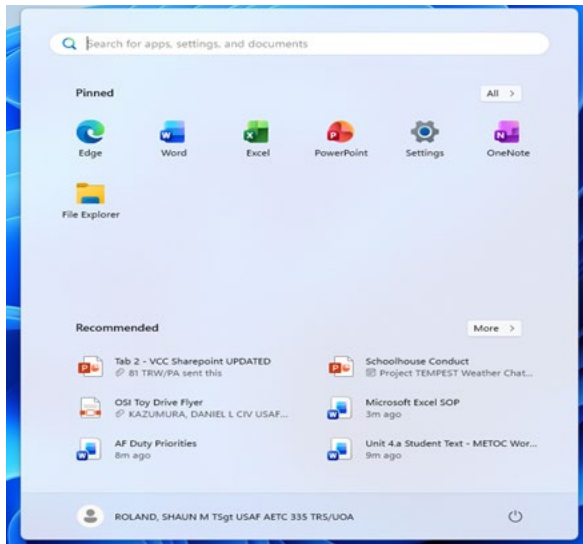
1. Have the full number prepared and ready to dial, either by memory or written down.
 - a. Instructors should provide you with a contact number during lab days.
2. For local numbers on Keesler AFB that begin with 376 or 377, you do not need to use any area code.
3. If after 5 rings, usually the individual(s) are away from the phone or are busy doing other things. You can either try calling again later or continue calling if it is an urgent matter.
4. If contact is made with the individual you are seeking, offer a greeting that contains your basic information. Maintain a polite and professional manner during the entire conversation.
5. There is a possibility you may get put on hold. Sometimes it may last for longer than usual, often with background music. Be respectful and ready to respond when they get back to the phone call.
6. Any technical issues that arise from the phones, to include outages, please inform your instructor.



Practice: Phone Etiquette

Microsoft Excel Basics

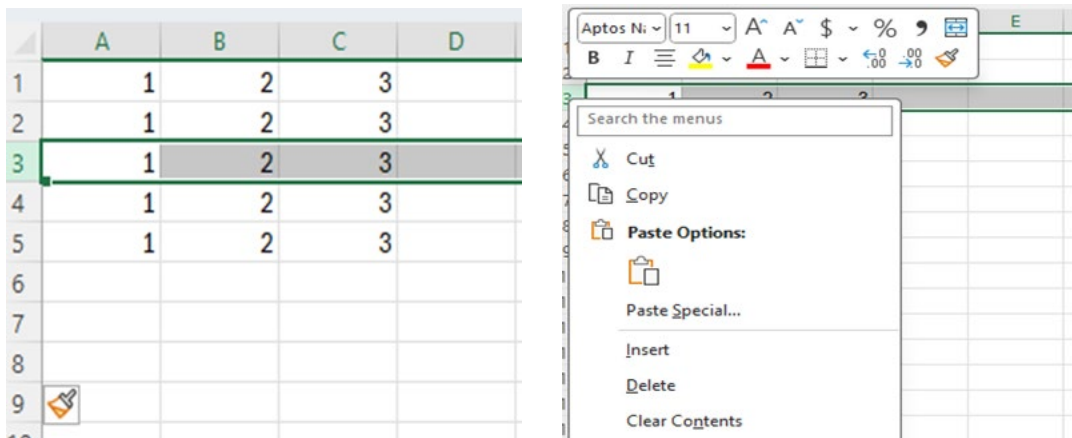
1. The Excel icon is green, with letter x. Select the appropriate working Excel document from the shared drive, email, etc. Or select a new blank worksheet from the start menu.



2. For a new worksheet, you can either select Blank workbook, or select a wide variety of templates, by clicking on “more templates” on the top far right.
3. The primary uses of Microsoft Excel include organizing, calculating, and analyzing data. Weather Forecasters typically use this program to store data such as for climatology, planning weather, mission execution forecasts, etc.
4. Each cell is marked by numerical rows, and alphabetic columns.
 - a. Ex: A1, A2, B1, B2

	A	B
1		
2		

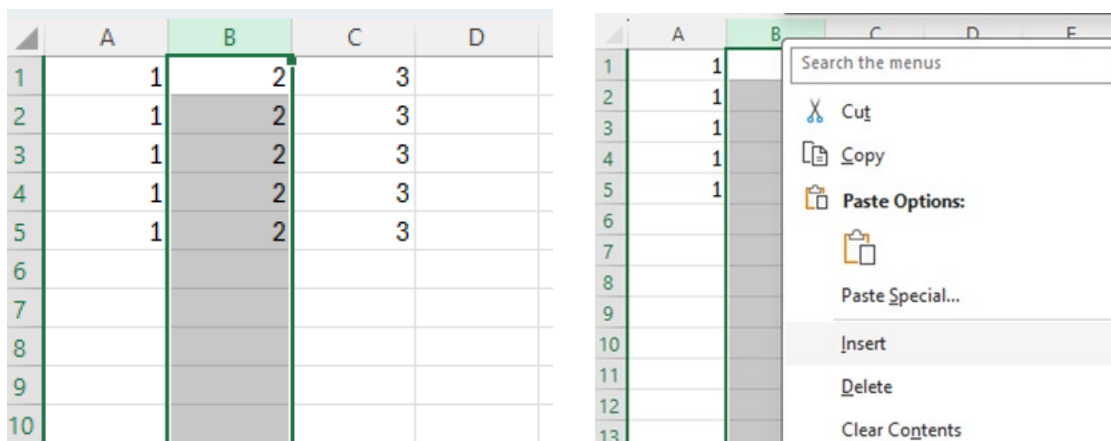
5. Rows:
 - a. For adding row: To add a new column, right click on the far-left numbered row and select “insert”. A new blank row will be added above.
 - b. For deleting row: To delete an existing row, right click on the far-left numbered row and select “delete”. The existing row will be deleted.
 - c. You can also remove data by selecting “clear contents”, without deleting any rows



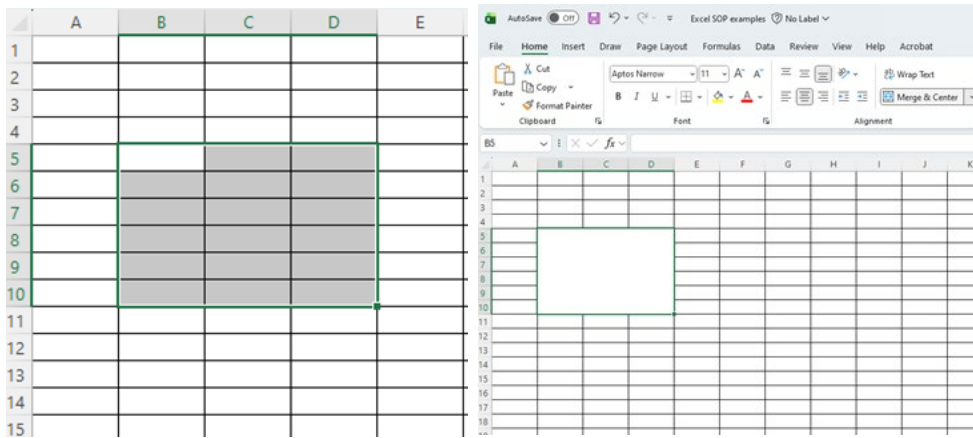
- d. Row Height: Standard row height in excel is 15. To adjust the height, either click between the rows at the top and drag to widen each row or input the value by right-clicking then selecting column width. Then input value.

6. Columns:

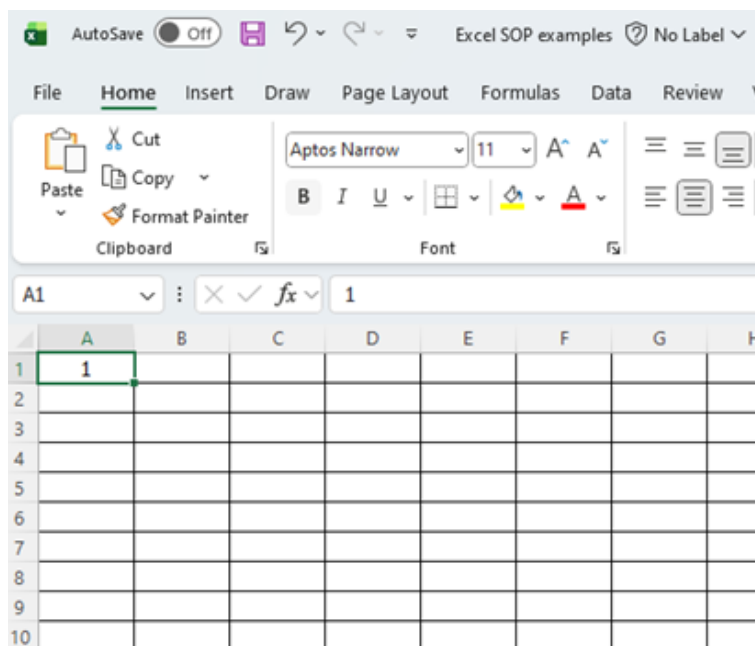
- For adding column: To add a new column, right click on the top lettered column and select “insert”. A new column will be added to the left.
- For deleting column: To delete a column, right click on the top lettered column and select “delete”. The existing column will be deleted.
- Column Width: Standard column width in excel is 8.43. To adjust the width, either click between the rows at the top and drag to widen the columns or input the value by right-clicking then selecting column width. Then input value.



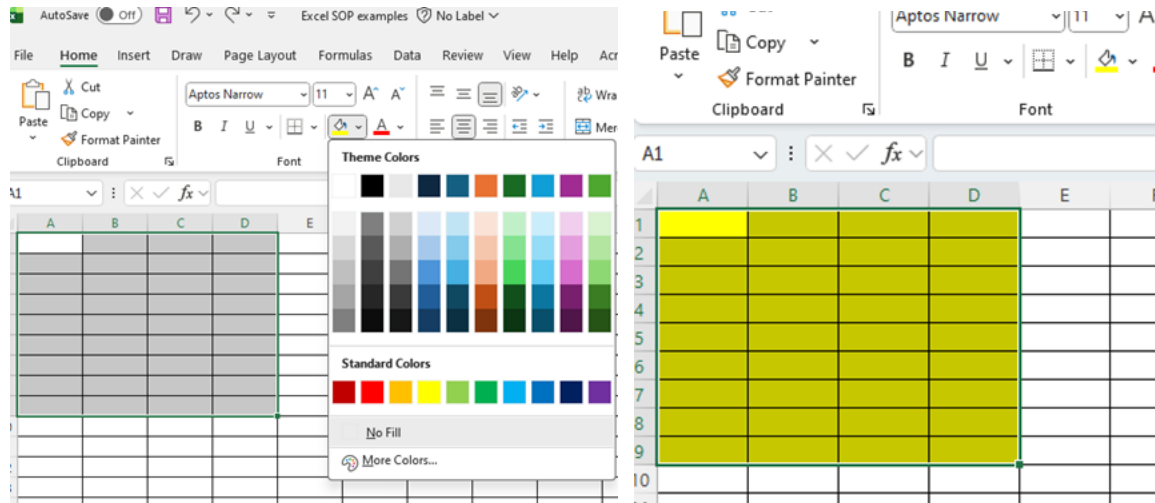
7. Merging cells: Cells are usually merged, to type in data such as sentences, paragraphs, etc. First, click and drag the cells you would like to merge. Then under the “Home” tab at the top, click on the option “Merge & Center” button at the top.



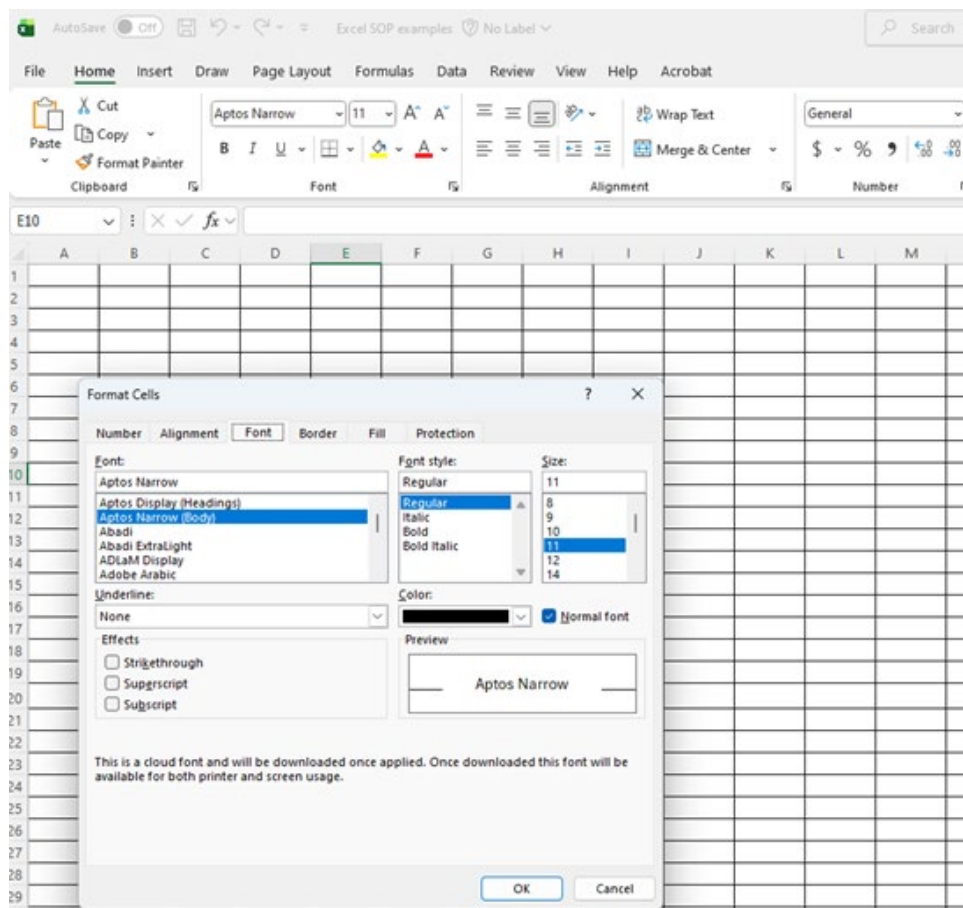
8. Aligning Cells: All content is automatically default to be aligned to the right. In order to change alignment, under the “home” tab you select the left, center, or right alignment.



9. Highlighting Cells: In order to highlight cells, click and drag the total cells you want to change color then under the “home” tab, select the paint icon. On the right dropdown arrow, you can change the color.



10. Changing Text Color and Font/Size: In order to change the text color, font, or size you click and drag the cells and under “file” you do have options to change these. Or you can “right click” and go to the Font tab and change the text characteristics as well.



Email Etiquette

Like phone calls, there will be times while you are on duty that you will be required to send emails through Outlook. When conducting communications through email it is important to remain as professional as you do over the phone. Unlike phone calls, you will have more time to think through what you want to say and how you want to say it.

Microsoft Outlook Basics

Microsoft Outlook is the official email used in the Air Force. It is important to familiarize yourself with the program and understand the basics. In Outlook, there will be different folders to choose from, like any other email program.

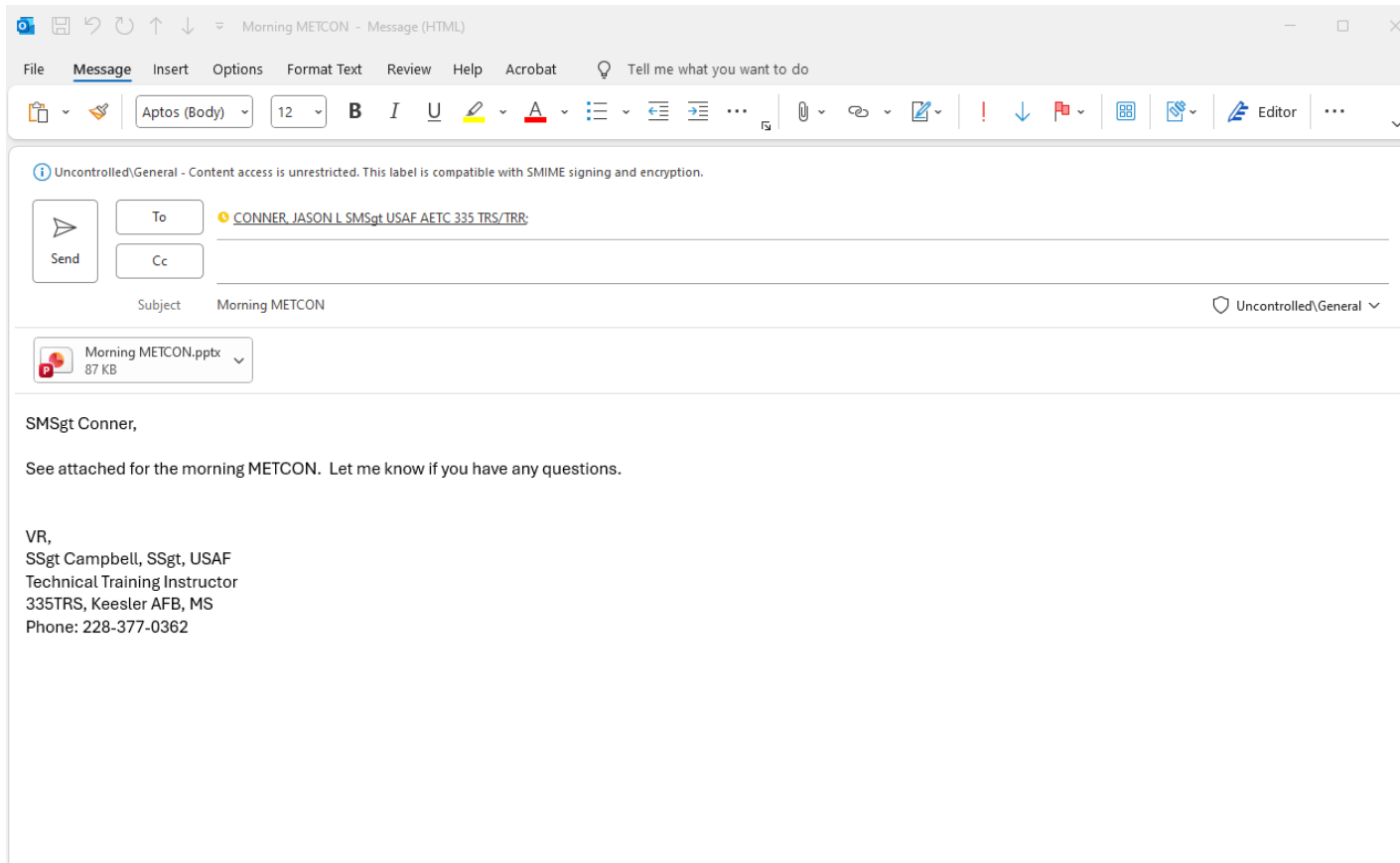
TO: When you begin a new email, you can insert the email of the person(s) you are sending an email to, or you can search the Global address book by hitting the “To” button.

CC: If you need to keep certain people informed of your email traffic / information given, but they are not the primary recipient of the email, you can add them to the CC Block of the email.

SUBJECT: You will always include a Subject when composing an email. Be sure to make this line as concise and informational as you can to ensure the person receiving the email can understand why they are receiving this email prior to opening it up.

BODY: In the body of the email, you will begin with a greeting to the person(s) you are emailing. When emailing a single person always includes their rank or title and their name (Mr./Mrs./MSgt/Captain Last Name). When emailing a group of people, be professional while including everyone (ALCON, 335th Bulls, Team, etc.).

As you end your email attach your signature block to every email to ensure the person(s) receiving the email have contact information for you in case they need to contact you again. If you have attachments in your email, ensure you attach all files necessary before sending.



Practice: Excel / Email Etiquette

Duty Checklists

As you continue working through your shifts, most METOC locations will have an electronic checklist that has tasks for you to complete throughout your shift. There will be a spot for you to put your initials once you complete a task. This is being done to help manage your time and ensure all required tasks are completed, and as accountability if anyone needs to check which forecaster completed certain tasks if there is an error or if any clarification is needed.

When completing the checklist:

- Do not pencil-whip the tasks or sign off on them without completing or verifying them.
- Do not wait until the last minute to complete a task. Give yourself enough time.
- Do not complete tasks unreasonably ahead of the prescribed time.
- Always sign off on the task once it is completed, and close to the prescribed time.
- Do not skip tasks, follow them in the listed order.
- Keep the checklist open on a monitor or tab somewhere throughout your shift.
- If you cannot perform the task for whatever reason, you should delegate to another coworker or document the reason why that task cannot be completed.

Time	STUDENT Duty Checklist Items	WX INT:
0730L	- PC START	
0745L	- OBSERVATION 1 DUE	
0845L	- OBSERVATION 2 DUE	
0930L	- ANALYSIS WORKSHEET DUE	
0945L	- OBSERVATION 3 DUE	
1030L	- MODEL VERIFICATION WORKSHEET DUE	
1045L	- OBSERVATION 4 DUE	
1145L	- OBSERVATION 5 DUE	
1220L	- FORECAST REASONING WORKSHEET DUE - EMAIL INSTRUCTOR COMPLETED: DUTY CHECKLIST, OBSERVATION FORM, ANALYSIS WORKSHEET, MODEL VERIFICATION REASONING WORKSHEET, FORECAST REASONING WORKSHEET.	
1230L	- PC END: ALL PRODUCTS MUST BE SUBMITTED TO INSTRUCTOR	

Duty Priorities

For each assigned weather assignment, there will be specific duty priorities posted that you should be familiar with. When you have two or more duties that need to be accomplished at the same time, you can use the duty priority list to complete tasks in order of importance. Despite pressure from your leadership, tasks of higher priority must be completed first. Failure to do so could jeopardize the mission and place unnecessary risk on personnel or assets.

For example, you receive notification of an aircraft in-flight emergency and fire alarm goes off at your location at the same time. You must evacuate the building first, before being able to respond to the in-flight emergency.

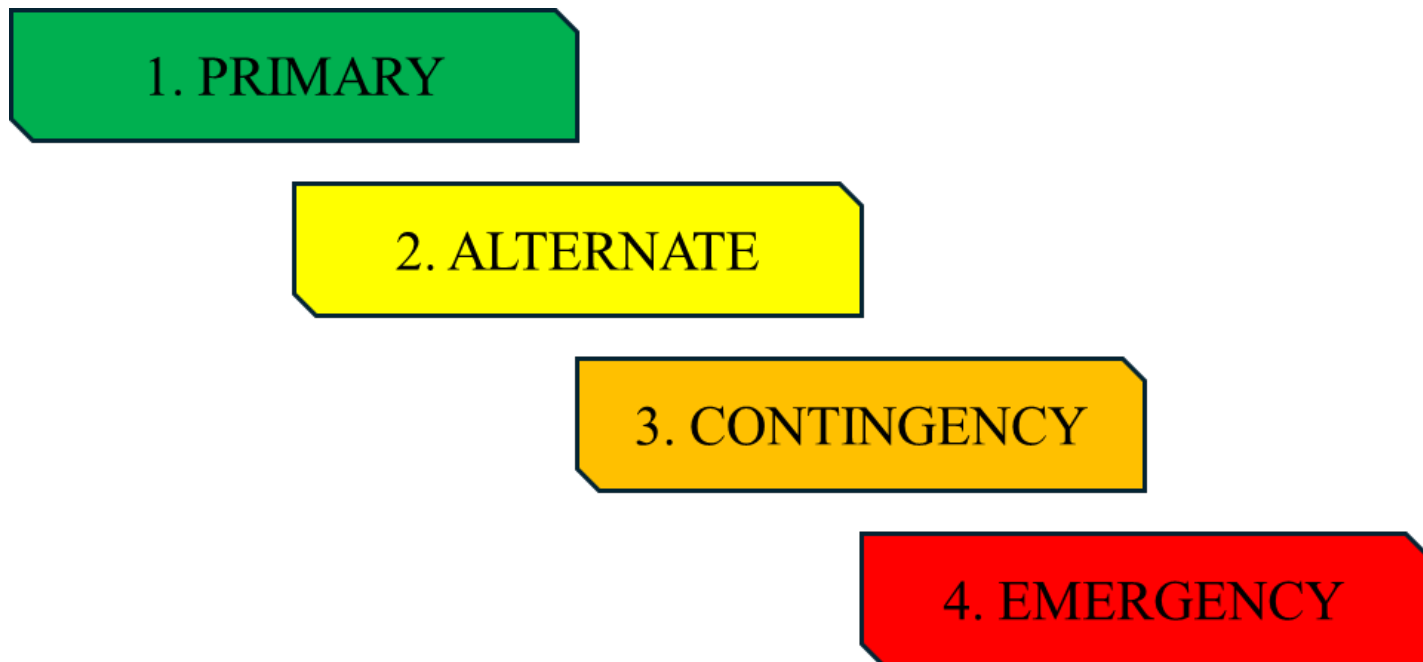
Duty Priorities (Training)	
#1	Execute Base Weather Station Evacuation
#2	Issue Imminent Weather Warnings
#3	Respond to Aircraft / Ground Emergencies
#4	Disseminate SPECI Observations
#5	Disseminate Hourly METAR Observations
#6	Produce / Disseminate METOC Products
#7	Provide General Weather Information to the Commander
#8	Amend Weather Products
#9	Provide Staff Weather Briefings
#10	Accomplish Administrative Tasks

Practice: Duty Checklist and Duty Priorities

Workplace Operation Impacts & P.A.C.E

P.A.C.E. Planning

The P.A.C.E. framework was developed to ensure there is no single point of failure in any military operation. This framework is used in nearly every aspect of military operations from communication networks, aircraft missions, and training exercises. The goal of this section is to identify each phase of a P.A.C.E. plan, and where each phase would be used in a scenario.



The **Primary** plan is the standard way your unit operates. This plan accounts for multitudes of variables and remains viable so long as any alterations to the plan are minor. There should be little to no risk involved in the primary plan, any risks will be well mitigated.

The **Alternate** plan is the “second best” option for the unit or operation in question. The Alternate plan is expected to accomplish mission priorities from the primary plan and is only put into effect when an unexpected event takes place, requiring a shift in operations that result in the primary plan being unusable.

The **Contingency** plan is the third option for the unit or operation in question, and is reserved to account for large, unexpected changes to both the primary and alternate plans. The contingency plan is expected to accomplish mission priorities where able and eliminate risk where able.

The **Emergency** plan is the “last resort” for the unit or operation in question. This plan is reserved for instances where accomplishing mission priorities or saving resources is the most important task at hand. The emergency plan is only exercised if the primary, alternate, and contingency plans have all been rendered unusable. Risk is inherently high with the emergency plan and should only be used if necessary.

PACE Example:

Communications Mission: Sending a message to a friend.

1. **Primary:** Send them a text message
2. **Alternate:** Call them

3. Contingency: Contact someone who knows how to get ahold of them

4. Emergency: Physically travel to the friend to relay the message in person

Notice the primary plan is easy, quick, and effective, making the primary plan the best option for the mission.

In this scenario, assume you attempt to text, but someone changed the language of your keyboard to a language you do not speak. Texting your friend is no longer an option, so you must use an alternate plan to get ahold of them. Calling your friend accomplishes the same goal, with minor setbacks and inconveniences but is the next best option for accomplishing the mission.

Next, assume that you call but their phone goes straight to voicemail. You must now enact the contingency plan. You would contact someone who is usually aware of the location and/or activities of your friend. You contact that person, but they have not heard from your friend in a few days. The contingency plan has now failed, and you must take emergency action to accomplish the mission by whatever means necessary.

You decide to physically travel to their house and make direct contact with them. You get the message to them making your emergency plan the best and last resort option to complete the mission.

Practice: Operational Impacts / P.A.C.E.

PC: METOC Workplace Operations